

A FREE GUIDE BY VANESSA STOYKOV

THE ADULT CHILDREN MONEY GUIDE

11 CONVERSATIONS THAT CHANGE EVERYTHING

The conversations most families never have — about money, deposits, inheritance, debt and what love really looks like when your children are grown.

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WHY I WROTE THIS

LET'S GET REAL ABOUT MONEY

For 25 years I have been telling financial stories. And the story I keep hearing — in boardrooms, on stages, in my DMs — is this one: **adult children and money**.

It does not matter if the family has \$50,000 or \$5 million. The conversations are the same. The guilt is the same. The silence is the same.

This guide is not about telling you what to do with your money. It is about giving you the words to finally have the conversations you have been avoiding. Use the reflection questions at the end of each chapter to start there — with yourself, before you sit down with your kids.

"The most valuable thing you can give your adult children is not your money. It is the financial wisdom to never need it."

— VANESSA STOYKOV

WHAT'S INSIDE

01 You Gave Them the Deposit

02 Should You Help Them Buy?

03 The Inheritance Conversation

04 Adult Children & Credit Card Debt

05 How Much Help Is Too Much?

06 When They Want to Move Back Home

07 Should They Pay Rent at Home?

08 They Earn More Than You

09 One Child Needs More Help

10 Your Retirement vs Their Needs

11 The Conversation That Starts It All

THE BANK OF MUM & DAD

01

YOU GAVE THEM THE DEPOSIT. BUT DID YOU PROTECT YOURSELF?

Australian parents are tipping hundreds of thousands into their children's homes — and most of it goes in on a handshake. No agreement. No paperwork. Just love and hope. Then the relationship breaks down. Or the marriage ends. And suddenly your money is sitting in someone else's divorce. **Gone. Because you never wrote it down.**

Helping your children is not the problem. Doing it without protecting yourself is. Generosity and a paper trail can absolutely live together.



THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH

Before you hand over a dollar, decide: is this a gift or a loan? Write it down. Have a lawyer look at it. That piece of paper is not a lack of trust — it is love with clarity.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If your child's relationship ended tomorrow, would the money you gave them come back to you — and do you have anything in writing to support that?

Have you had an honest conversation with your child about whether your contribution is a gift or a loan — and what the conditions are?

FIRST HOME BUYERS

02

SHOULD YOU HELP YOUR ADULT CHILD BUY THEIR FIRST HOME?

You want to help your kid buy their first home. But here is the question nobody asks first: **Will helping them leave you short?** I see it all the time. Women dip into their retirement savings to give their child a deposit. Then they are the ones who cannot retire.

Helping is not wrong. But it has to be a decision, not a reflex. Is it a gift or a loan? What happens if they split up? Put it in writing. Love and clarity are not opposites. Help from a position of strength — never from guilt. Secure your own future first. Then give freely.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Secure your own financial future before you open your wallet. A parent who runs out of money becomes a burden. A parent who plans becomes a model.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If you contributed to your child's home deposit today, what would the real impact be on your retirement date and your own financial security?

Are you helping because you genuinely have the capacity — or because you feel unable to say no? What would it sound like to say yes from strength instead of guilt?

INHERITANCE

03

SHOULD YOU TELL YOUR ADULT CHILDREN ABOUT THEIR INHERITANCE?

Most women get this completely wrong. They keep it a secret. They are scared the money will make their kids lazy. Or that talking about death is bad luck. So they say nothing. And then they are gone — and there is a mess.

But here is the thing nobody tells you. **The conversation is not about the number. It is about your values.** What this money is for. The life you built and what you want it to mean. You do not have to reveal every dollar. But you can share the why — and do that while you are alive.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

It is not the secrecy that protects your children. It is the clarity you give them — while you are still here to give it.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What values do you want your wealth to represent after you are gone — and have you ever said those words out loud to your children?

What is your biggest fear about having the inheritance conversation — and is that fear based on evidence, or assumption?

DEBT

04

ADULT CHILDREN AND CREDIT CARD DEBT: SHOULD PARENTS STEP IN?

Your adult child just told you they are drowning in credit card debt. Do you pay it off? Here is the thing nobody says out loud: **every time you rescue them, you teach them they will always be rescued.** And you quietly chip away at your own retirement to do it.

I am not saying do not help. I am saying help differently. Sit beside them. Open the statement together. Build the plan together. The most generous thing you can give them is not your money. It is the skill to never need it again.



THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH

Real help builds capacity. The goal is not to pay the debt — it is to make sure they never accumulate it again.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Have you helped your child out of debt before? Did the behaviour change — or did the debt return? What did that teach you about what kind of help actually works?

What would it look like to sit alongside your child through this debt — without taking ownership of it for them?

BOUNDARIES

05

HOW MUCH FINANCIAL HELP IS TOO MUCH?

You just paid your adult child's rent again, did you not? Here is what nobody tells you: **every time you swoop in and fix it, you send a message** — that you do not think they can do it themselves. And the bills keep coming. Because you have become the plan.

Real love is not a blank cheque. It is teaching them to swim. The hardest thing? Watching them struggle a little. But that struggle is where they learn. So next time, before you transfer the money, ask yourself one question: am I solving this — or am I robbing them of solving it themselves?

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

The moment you become the plan, you stop being the parent. The boundary is not rejection — it is the most loving thing you can do.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

When you help your child financially, is it coming from a place of genuine capacity and choice — or from fear of conflict, guilt, or the need to feel needed?

What would a clear and loving financial boundary with your adult child actually look like — and what is stopping you from setting it?

HOME

06

MY DAUGHTER WANTS TO MOVE BACK HOME AT 34. AM I WRONG FOR WANTING MY LIFE BACK?

Carol wrote to me. Thirty-four-year-old daughter, two kids, freshly separated. And for the first time in decades, Carol's home is finally quiet. She feels selfish for not wanting to give that up. Carol — **wanting your own life does not make you a bad mother.** You spent thirty years putting everyone else first. Wanting peace now? That is not selfish. That is earned.

If she moves in, make it a transition plan — not an open door. A timeline. A contribution. Milestones. Because helping her is not the same as rescuing her. You can open your door and still keep your future.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Compassion and accountability are not opposites. The most loving version of help comes with a plan for what independence looks like — and when.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If your adult child did move back home, what specific conditions, timelines and contributions would make that feel sustainable — and have you ever said them out loud?

What does your own life — your space, your peace, your needs — look like right now? And how much of that are you willing to negotiate, and for how long?

LIVING AT HOME

07

MY ADULT CHILD STILL LIVES AT HOME. SHOULD THEY PAY RENT?

Here is what most parents do. They say nothing. They cover the groceries, the petrol, the phone bill. And they tell themselves it is love. **But silence is not love. It is a bill you are quietly paying.**

The rent was never really about the money. It is about teaching them what things actually cost. How to budget. How to stand on their own two feet. That is not punishment — that is the most loving thing you can do. So do not charge in silence, and do not avoid it in silence either. Sit them down. Say: let us talk about what comes next.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

The conversation about rent is really a conversation about adulthood. It is the kindest thing a parent can start.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What is your adult child contributing to the household right now — financially, practically and emotionally? Are you satisfied with that balance, or are you quietly carrying more than you should?

What skills or financial habits do you wish your child had by now — and what role has the current living arrangement played in why they do not?

EARNING MORE

08

MY ADULT CHILD EARNS MORE THAN ME BUT STILL WANTS HELP

Your kid earns more than you do — and they are still asking you for money. Bigger salary. Nicer car. And still the deposit, the wedding, the "just till payday." And you say yes. Because you do not know how to say anything else.

Here is the thing nobody says out loud. **Helping them is not the problem. The silence is.** They do not know what it costs you. Because you have never told them. So try this: "I love helping you. And I need us to be honest about what I can actually afford." One sentence. That is where it starts.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Your child cannot respect a boundary they do not know exists. Telling them the truth about your limits is a gift, not a rejection.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Have you ever told your child — clearly and honestly — what your financial limits are? If not, what has been stopping you from having that conversation?

Does your child know the real state of your finances — your retirement savings, your income, your own goals? Would knowing that change how they ask for help?

FAIRNESS

09

WHAT IF ONE CHILD NEEDS MORE FINANCIAL HELP THAN THE OTHERS?

One child is thriving. The other is struggling. So you quietly help the one who needs it — and you say nothing. Because saying it out loud feels like picking a favourite.

But here is what I have learned. **It is not the help that breeds resentment — it is the secrecy.** Silence does not protect your children. Equal is not always fair. Fair means meeting each child where they are. Say that out loud — to all of them.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Transparency does not create conflict. Secrecy does. The bravest thing you can do for your family is say: "I am helping differently because the need is different. This is not about love — it is about life."

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Are you helping one child more than another right now — and have you told your other children why? What are you afraid would happen if you did?

How will you account for financial imbalances between your children in your estate plan — and does everyone understand the reasoning behind your decisions?

RETIREMENT

10

YOUR RETIREMENT VS THEIR NEEDS: THE CONVERSATION NOBODY WINS

Here is the conversation I see play out in slow motion. A parent depletes their superannuation to support an adult child. Ten years later, the child is fine — and the parent has nothing left. **There is no rescue plan for the person who gave everything away.**

I am not saying do not be generous. I am saying: protect yourself first, then give from the overflow. Because the most devastating financial story I know is not of a person who spent too much on themselves. It is the woman who gave her retirement away — and then had to depend on the very child she was trying to help.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Your superannuation is not a gift fund. It is your future. Protecting it is not greed — it is wisdom. A financially secure parent is a gift to their children that lasts a lifetime.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Do you know exactly what your retirement will look like at your current savings rate — and have you modelled what happens if you help your child the way you are currently planning to?

If you ran out of money in retirement, who would you lean on — and have you thought about what that would cost them emotionally and financially?

THE BEGINNING

11

THE CONVERSATION THAT STARTS IT ALL

After everything in this guide, there is really just one conversation to have. And it starts not with your children — but with yourself.

What do I actually want my money to do? Not what I think I should want. Not what would look generous. What do I honestly want — for my own life, my own retirement, my own peace of mind — and then from that place of clarity, what do I want to leave behind?

Because the families who get this right — they are not the ones with the most money. They are the ones who had the most honest conversations. Start the conversation now. While there is still time to shape it.

**THE COURAGEOUS TRUTH**

Forty years of financial silence ends with one brave conversation. It does not have to be perfect. It just has to begin.

YOUR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

If you could have one honest financial conversation with your adult child that you have been avoiding — what would you say, and what has been stopping you?

Looking at your family right now — what is the one financial decision or conversation that, if handled well, would change everything for the next generation?

WHAT COMES NEXT

LET'S KEEP THE CONVERSATION GOING

This guide is just the beginning. Every week I share courageous conversations about money — straight into your inbox and on social.

**STEP 1 – SUBSCRIBE TO THE NEWSLETTER**

Weekly insights on money, life and the conversations your family needs to have.

vanessastoykov.com/newsletter

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